

# THE NURTURE MOMS

## POSTPARTUM NOURISHMENT

A simple guide to nourishing yourself after birth

**Practical food ideas for recovery, energy and everyday motherhood.**

| RECOVER        | NOURISH          | SUSTAIN                  |
|----------------|------------------|--------------------------|
| Protein + iron | Colour + variety | Hydration + simple meals |

Created by The Nurture Moms

For moms who deserve nourishment too. ☐

### Important

This is a general educational guide, not a personalised medical or diet plan. Your nutritional needs can vary with your health, recovery, breastfeeding status, medications and medical history. Speak with your doctor or qualified nutrition professional for individual advice.

# 1. Postpartum nutrition: the simple foundation

After birth, food is not about “bouncing back.” It is about giving your body the nourishment it needs while you recover, care for your baby and, if breastfeeding, support lactation.

## Build meals around four simple ideas:

- Include a protein source at meals.
- Add vegetables or fruit for colour and variety.
- Choose whole grains, pulses or other nourishing carbohydrate sources.
- Include healthy fats and drink regularly according to thirst.

### Keep it realistic

You do not need a perfect postpartum diet. A simple home-cooked meal, a bowl of dal with rice, eggs with vegetables, curd with fruit or a handful of nuts can all be part of a nourishing day.

## 2. The nutrients to pay attention to

A varied diet helps cover many nutrient needs. Some nutrients deserve particular attention during the postpartum period and breastfeeding.

| NUTRIENT         | FOOD SOURCES                                                                                 | WHY IT MATTERS                                              |
|------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------|
| Protein          | Eggs, dal, lentils, beans, paneer/curd, fish, chicken, meat, tofu                            | Supports tissue repair, maintenance and overall nutrition.  |
| Iron             | Lentils, beans, leafy greens, meat, fish, eggs, iron-fortified foods                         | Important for blood and oxygen transport.                   |
| Calcium          | Curd/yogurt, milk, paneer, calcium-set tofu, some leafy greens                               | Supports bones, teeth and normal body functions.            |
| Vitamin D        | Fortified foods and selected dietary sources; supplementation may be advised for some people | Supports bone and immune health.                            |
| Iodine & choline | Dairy, eggs, seafood and other varied foods                                                  | Needs can be important during breastfeeding.                |
| B12              | Dairy, eggs, meat, fish or fortified foods                                                   | Especially important to consider in vegetarian/vegan diets. |

CDC notes that needs for some nutrients, including iodine and choline, increase during lactation, and that some breastfeeding mothers may benefit from supplements depending on their diet and individual circumstances.

### 3. Your postpartum plate

Instead of counting every calorie, use a simple plate pattern for everyday meals.

| <b>½ PLATE</b>                              | <b>¼ PLATE</b>                                        | <b>¼ PLATE</b>                                           |
|---------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------|
| Vegetables +/-or fruit                      | Protein: dal, egg, fish, chicken, paneer, beans, tofu | Rice, roti, oats, millet, potato or another grain/starch |
| Add a source of healthy fat as appropriate. | Choose foods you enjoy and can prepare realistically. | Pair meals with water or another suitable drink.         |

#### Easy Indian meal combinations

- Dal + rice + vegetable + curd
- Roti + egg/paneer + vegetable sabzi + fruit
- Vegetable khichdi + curd
- Oats + milk/curd + fruit + nuts/seeds in a safe form
- Idli + sambar + vegetable
- Rice + fish/chicken + vegetable + curd

#### The goal

Think nourishing and sustainable — not restrictive. Your food should support your recovery and your real life.

## 4. Easy postpartum meals for busy days

Some days you may have 10 minutes, one hand free and a hungry baby nearby. Keep a few simple options ready.

| TIME           | EASY OPTION                                                              |
|----------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Breakfast      | Vegetable oats / poha + egg or curd + fruit                              |
| Mid-morning    | Fruit + nuts/seeds or plain yogurt                                       |
| Lunch          | Dal + rice/roti + vegetable + curd                                       |
| Evening        | Roasted chana + fruit or a simple homemade snack                         |
| Dinner         | Khichdi + vegetables + curd, or roti + dal + sabzi                       |
| Emergency meal | Frozen/home-prepared dal or curry + rice/roti + quickly cooked vegetable |

### Prep once, use twice

- Cook a batch of dal and freeze portions.
- Wash/chop vegetables when you have energy.
- Keep boiled eggs or other ready-to-eat protein options available.
- Keep fruit, curd/yogurt and nuts/seeds available for quick snacks.
- Accept help with cooking when it is offered.

## 5. Breastfeeding & nourishment

If you are breastfeeding, you do not need a special “breastfeeding diet.” A varied, balanced diet is encouraged. CDC notes that well-nourished breastfeeding mothers generally need additional energy compared with before pregnancy, but the exact amount varies by the individual and feeding pattern.

### Simple priorities

- Eat regular, nourishing meals rather than skipping meals.
- Include protein and iron-rich foods regularly.
- Eat a varied diet rather than unnecessarily eliminating foods.
- Drink according to thirst and keep water accessible.
- If you follow a vegetarian or vegan diet, pay particular attention to nutrients such as B12, iron, iodine, calcium, vitamin D and omega-3 fats with professional guidance when needed.

### Important

You generally do not need to avoid specific foods just because you are breastfeeding. If you think your baby is reacting to something in your diet, discuss the symptoms with your pediatrician/healthcare professional before making major dietary restrictions.

## 6. Supplements: don't guess

Postpartum supplement needs are individual. Some people continue prenatal vitamins or are advised to take specific nutrients; others may need targeted supplementation based on diet, blood tests, medical history or breastfeeding status.

### Ask your healthcare professional about

- Iron or folate, especially if you had anaemia or significant blood loss.
- Vitamin D or B12 if intake/status may be low.
- Iodine and other nutrients during breastfeeding.
- Calcium or other supplements when dietary intake is insufficient.

#### A practical rule

Food first is a useful foundation, but supplements can be appropriate when there is a documented need or professional recommendation. Do not restart high-dose iron or other supplements solely because you feel tired without discussing the cause.

WHO guidance includes context-specific postpartum iron/folate supplementation recommendations, particularly in settings where gestational anaemia is a public-health concern. Individual treatment of anaemia should follow local clinical guidance.

## 7. Hydration & everyday habits

Keep hydration simple. Have water available where you feed your baby, carry a bottle when you leave home and drink regularly according to thirst.

### Small habits that help

- Keep a water bottle near your feeding chair or usual resting place.
- Pair meals with a drink.
- Include hydrating foods such as fruits, vegetables, soups and curd/yogurt.
- Don't rely on sugary drinks as your main source of hydration.
- Ask someone else to refill your bottle when you are busy with the baby.

### No perfection needed

Postpartum life changes daily. A nourishing snack is still better than waiting for the “perfect” meal.

## 8. A simple 7-day meal framework

Use this as inspiration, not a fixed diet plan. Swap foods according to your culture, preferences, allergies, budget and medical needs.

| DAY | BREAKFAST                  | LUNCH                          | DINNER                          |
|-----|----------------------------|--------------------------------|---------------------------------|
| 1   | Veg poha + egg/curd        | Dal + rice + veg + curd        | Roti + paneer/egg + sabzi       |
| 2   | Oats + fruit + nuts/seeds  | Rajma/chole + rice + salad/veg | Khichdi + curd + veg            |
| 3   | Idli + sambar              | Rice + fish/chicken + veg      | Roti + dal + sabzi              |
| 4   | Upma + fruit + curd        | Dal + roti + veg               | Veg rice + egg/paneer + curd    |
| 5   | Dosa + sambar              | Khichdi + curd + veg           | Roti + chicken/fish/dal + sabzi |
| 6   | Ragi/oats porridge + fruit | Rice + dal + veg + curd        | Idli/dosa + sambar + veg        |
| 7   | Poha/upma + protein        | Roti/rice + dal + veg + curd   | Simple family meal + vegetable  |

Snacks: fruit + nuts/seeds, curd/yogurt, roasted chana, homemade snack, boiled egg, or another nourishing option that suits you.

## 9. When to get personalised help

Talk to a doctor or qualified nutrition professional if you have ongoing or significant symptoms such as severe fatigue, dizziness, shortness of breath, persistent weakness, heavy bleeding, significant weight change, or concerns about your recovery or nutrition.

### Extra support may be useful if you have

- Anaemia or a history of low iron.
- Thyroid disease, diabetes or other medical conditions.
- A vegetarian or vegan diet with concerns about nutrient intake.
- Food allergies or significant dietary restrictions.
- A history of eating disorders or difficult relationships with food.
- Breastfeeding concerns that need lactation support.

### Your postpartum chapter matters

Recovery is not a race. Nourish yourself with patience, ask for help when you need it, and remember that taking care of yourself is part of taking care of your family.

## THE NURTURE MOMS

**Move. Nourish. Connect. Pass it on. **

### Need personalised nutrition support?

**[Book a 1:1 Nutrition Consultation →](#)**

## Sources & safety notes

This guide uses current public guidance from WHO and CDC. Recommendations can vary by individual and country; personalised concerns should be discussed with a healthcare professional.

### **CDC — Maternal Diet and Breastfeeding**

<https://www.cdc.gov/breastfeeding-special-circumstances/hcp/diet-micronutrients/maternal-diet.html>

### **WHO — Nutrition for a healthy life**

<https://www.who.int/europe/news-room/fact-sheets/item/nutrition---maintaining-a-healthy-lifestyle>

### **WHO — Healthy diet**

<https://www.who.int/news-room/fact-sheets/detail/healthy-diet>

### **WHO — Recommendations on maternal and newborn care for a positive postnatal experience**

<https://iris.who.int/bitstream/handle/10665/352658/9789240045989-eng.pdf>

#### **Website use**

This is designed as a free The Nurture Moms resource. Add your official logo, social links and a clear CTA to your Nutrition Consultation. Keep it educational and avoid presenting it as a personalised medical diet plan.